INTRODUCTION

Advertising is one form of mass communication. A classified ad from around 1000 BCE offered a reward (a gold coin) to anyone finding and returning a runaway slave. Johannes Gutenberg, an inventor and metallurgist, introduced movable-type printing to Europe in the fifteenth century, which allowed for the printed mass communication of advertising. The Industrial Revolution of the nineteenth century cultivated commercialism and transportation of national publications, including a large number of magazines. Advertising proliferated on the radio after 1920, on television after 1945, and on the Internet starting in the mid-1990s.

Psychologists study advertising as a form of communication in the context of cognition and psycholinguistics. Consumers "read" advertisements, whether in print, on television, or online, similarly to the way they read books. Therefore, one way to examine how consumers understand and react to advertisements is by researching comprehension of narrative scripts. For advertisements to effectively change consumer attitudes, their message must be understood. Psychologists study how consumers process the information in advertisements. Sometimes information processing leads to miscomprehension, which, often unintentionally, can create in the consumer false ideas about the product.

From a more social-cognitive and humanistic perspective, psychologists look at the appeals advertisers make to human needs. Advertisements associate basic needs and natural responses to those needs with their products. Advertisers classically condition consumers to respond to their products as they would to any stimulus naturally satisfying a need. Sometimes these associations are not consciously made.

NARRATIVE SCRIPT

The first step in changing consumer attitudes toward an advertised product is to persuade the consumer that the informational content of the advertisement is true. One way advertisers create belief in the consumer is by following a narrative script, a simple plot such as a child might hear when a parent reads a story.

The narrative script is a knowledge structure composed of exposition, complication, and resolution. The exposition introduces the characters and settings of the story, the complication is a developing problem, and the resolution is the solution to the problem. Many advertisements take the form of the narrative script to facilitate comprehension and belief. For example, John, Jane, and their daughter Judy are playing at the park (exposition). While swinging, Judy falls on the ground, scraping her knee (complication). Jane soothes Judy and dresses her wound by applying a plastic bandage coated with an antibacterial agent (resolution). The consumer is comfortable with the narrative script as an understandable and entertaining format. The advertiser is able to hold the audience's attention. The resolution is associated with the product (bandages).